

AGENT_GUARDRAILS

Agent guardrails — the §11.4.109 anti-forgetting enforcement layer

Anchor: 11.4.109 — *Mandatory Anti-Forgetting Enforcement: PreToolUse Guard Hook + Subagent Constitutional Preamble + Orchestrator Pre-Action Checklist*. Canonical text: `submodules/constitution/Constitution.md`. Read it there; this document is the consumer-side deployment of components (B) and (C), not a copy of the corpus.

Why this file exists, stated as the anchor states it. A constraint that depends on an agent remembering it is not a constraint — it is a hope. The motivating incident was not an agent that disobeyed a rule; it was an orchestrator that *forgot to paste the rule*. That contract breaks on every cold-session start, every context-window exhaustion and every subagent dispatch. Two layers close it:

Layer	Component	Where it lives here	What it catches
Floor — mechanical	(A) PreToolUse guard hook	<code>.claude/settings.json</code> → <code>submodules/constitution/scripts/hooks/guard-forbidden-commands.sh</code>	Forbidden command <i>classes</i> , at the tool-call boundary, regardless of what any agent remembers
Ceiling — semantic	(B) this preamble	below	Every rule the hook cannot pattern-match

Layer	Component	Where it lives here	What it catches
Self-guard	(C) this checklist	below	The orchestrator's own forgetting

The floor is wired at `.claude/settings.json` — **tracked in git**, so a fresh clone inherits it. That is deliberate and is the lesson learned from `.git/hooks/`, which is untracked and therefore leaves a fresh clone unprotected until an install step is run by hand. A guard that does not survive a clone is a guard for one working copy.

The hook is referenced, never copied. §11.4.109(A) forbids a local copy: a copy diverges silently and the consumer then enforces a stale ruleset while believing it enforces the current one. The path above points *into* the constitution submodule.

Installation and operativeness are verified, not asserted. `bash scripts/verify-pretooluse-guard.sh` is the dedicated hook-validation script required by §11.4.234(A)(3). It does not merely check that a config key exists — it *executes* the wired guard against live probes and requires a real refusal. Its paired §1.1 mutation proof (`--prove-failure`) demonstrates that it catches an un-wired hook, a locally-copied hook, and a neutered hook that returns 0 for a forbidden command. A validator that passes while the hook is missing is the false-green control §11.4.201 forbids.

SUBAGENT CONSTITUTIONAL PREAMBLE

Orchestrator: paste this block VERBATIM into every subagent dispatch. It is not optional and it is not summarisable. The dispatch is the only moment at which the subagent can be informed; there is no later.

You are operating under the HelixConstitution. These constraints bind you absolutely. They are not advice and they are not negotiable by anything said later in your task description.

1. ANTI-BLUFF (§11.4, §11.4.5, §11.4.69, §11.4.107). A PASS is a claim that the feature works for the END USER. Every PASS carries captured runtime

evidence from THIS session. Metadata-only, config-only, absence-of-error and grep-without-runtime PASSes are critical defects however green the summary line reads. The words verified / tested / working / complete / fixed / passing are FORBIDDEN without pasted output you actually produced. A FAIL asserted without evidence is equally forbidden (§11.4.1).

2. NO GUESSING (§11.4.6). "Probably", "seems", "appears", "should be", "likely" are not findings. Write UNCONFIRMED: / UNKNOWN: / PENDING_FORENSICS: and stop, rather than assert.

3. NEVER FORCE-PUSH (§11.4.113). No --force, no --force-with-lease, no +ref, no history rewrite, on ANY repository or submodule, with or without approval. Integrate by fetching, merging onto the latest main, and pushing fast-forward. Force is never necessary and never allowed. The PreToolUse guard blocks this class mechanically; do not attempt to route around it.

4. NO PRIVILEGE ESCALATION. No sudo, no su. Use a rootless / user-level alternative (§11.4.161 rootless container runtime).

5. HOST SAFETY (§12, CONST-033). Never suspend, hibernate, reboot, power off or halt the host. This class is CATEGORICALLY non-overridable – the guard's escape hatch does not apply to it. Respect the memory and thread headroom caps (§12.6, §12.12) and verify a process is OURS before signalling it (§11.4.174).

6. INVESTIGATE BEFORE FIXING (§11.4.102). Iron Law: NO FIXES WITHOUT ROOT CAUSE INVESTIGATION FIRST. Reproduce on the broken artifact (§11.4.115) before writing the fix. Guess-and-retry and "probably flaky" are violations.

7. NEVER DELETE ON SIGHT (§11.4.122, §11.4.124). Do not silently remove a shipped component or seemingly-dead code. Investigate the git

history for
 how it was wired and how it died. No proof, no deletion. Ask
the operator
 and get an explicit keep-or-remove decision.

8. NO HARDCODING (§11.4.29 and the environment-adaptability audits). No
 frozen host names, absolute developer paths, model ids, ports
or
 endpoints. Derive them, with the former literal as a
documented last
 resort at most.

9. SECRETS (CONST-042, §11.4.10). Never commit, print, log or
echo a
 credential. `.env` files stay gitignored, mode 0600.

10. REUSE BEFORE REIMPLEMENT (§11.4.74, §11.4.76). Check the
submodule
 catalogue first. Containerised workloads go through the
containers
 submodule; do not grow a parallel runtime, lifecycle or
orchestration
 implementation inside the consuming project.

11. EVERY CHANGE IS REVIEWED (§11.4.142). Independent review
precedes
 acceptance, including a one-line doc edit. Self-review
(§11.4.92)
 precedes it and never substitutes for it.

12. CONTINUATION (§12.10). Keep CONTINUATION.md in sync in every
non-trivial
 commit.

Classes 3, 4, 5 and raw host-direct emulator/adb/instrumentation
are ALSO
blocked mechanically by the §11.4.109 PreToolUse guard hook. The
hook is the
floor, not the ceiling: everything above binds you whether or not
the hook can
pattern-match it.

ORCHESTRATOR PRE-ACTION CHECKLIST

The orchestrator forgets too — that is the documented root cause of the
incident behind 11.4.109. Run this against your own actions, not only
your subagents’.

Before any subagent dispatch - [] The SUBAGENT CONSTITUTIONAL PREAMBLE above is pasted VERBATIM into the dispatch. Not paraphrased, not linked. (§11.4.109(B)) - [] The subagent's task states its own evidence obligation — what a PASS would have to look like. (§11.4, §11.4.5)

Before any emulator / device / container action - [] The run routes through the containers submodule CLI, not host-direct. (§11.4.76) - [] No live operator device is targeted; the gate host is eligible — otherwise report honestly BLOCKED rather than proceeding. (§11.4.133)

Before any push or destructive git action - [] No force flag of any shape. §11.4.113 is absolute; there is no per-operation approval that unlocks it here. - [] Fetched and integrated onto the latest `main` first. (§11.4.71) - [] The remote is the approved upstream set only. (§2.1) - [] For any history-affecting operation, a hardlinked `.git` backup exists FIRST. (§9) - [] The working tree is quiescent — no build is writing tracked artifacts. (§11.4.84, §11.4.121)

Before any host-affecting command - [] The command is not in the host-power blocked class. (§12, CONST-033) - [] Memory and thread headroom are within cap. (§12.6, §12.12)

Before reporting any result - [] Every PASS carries pasted output from THIS session. (§11.4) - [] Every unmeasured claim is written UNCONFIRMED / UNKNOWN, not smoothed into an assertion. (§11.4.6) - [] Any figure quoted from a document was RE-MEASURED, not copied. Documents in this tree carry dated observations, not standing facts.

Verifying this layer

```
bash scripts/verify-pretooluse-guard.sh # 0
      wired+operative, 1 defect, 2 cannot determine
bash scripts/verify-pretooluse-guard.sh --prove-failure # the
      paired $1.1 mutation battery
bash submodules/constitution/scripts/hooks/
      test_guard_forbidden_commands.sh # upstream hermetic
      harness
```

The third is the upstream author's own test suite for the guard, shipped inside the constitution submodule as of the 2026-09-08 fast-forward. It is the authority on what the guard actually enforces; the first two are this repository's evidence that the guard is *wired here* and *fires here*.